

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Quality Gate Decision Matrix

A transparent, criteria-based way to decide whether a release is ready — replacing "does it feel ready?" with an evidenced go / conditional-go / no-go.

Purpose

A quality gate is the checkpoint where you decide whether something is ready to progress — typically to release. This matrix makes that decision explicit and consistent: a defined set of criteria, each with a clear pass condition, producing a defensible go / conditional-go / no-go recommendation. It moves the release decision away from gut feel and away from whoever is most senior in the room, towards evidence everyone can see. Crucially, it frames the outcome as a risk-informed recommendation to the business, not a QA veto.

When to use it

- At each production release, as the readiness check.
- At promotion between environments or stages in a pipeline (as a lighter-weight version).
- When release decisions are currently made informally and inconsistently, or dominated by whoever pushes hardest.
- When you need to defend a decision to hold — or to release with known risk — after the fact.

Instructions

Agree the criteria and their pass conditions with Product and Engineering before you use the gate, not in the heat of a release. Separate mandatory criteria (a fail here means no-go regardless of everything else) from advisory ones (a fail raises risk but may be acceptable with mitigation). At the gate, mark each criterion Pass / Fail / N/A with a note. Then apply the decision rule below. Where the outcome is a conditional-go, record the accepted residual risk and who accepted it — that record is what protects the whole team if something goes wrong later.

Outcome	Rule
Go	All mandatory criteria pass and no advisory criterion carries unacceptable risk.
Conditional go	All mandatory criteria pass, but one or more advisory criteria fail; release proceeds with named mitigations and explicitly accepted residual risk.
No-go	Any mandatory criterion fails, or the accumulated advisory risk is judged unacceptable.

Worked example

A release gate applied to a Northstar Digital payments-related release. Note the outcome: a mandatory failure makes it a no-go even though most criteria pass — exactly the discipline the matrix exists to enforce.

Criterion	Type	Pass condition	Status	Notes
Critical / major defects	Mandatory	No open critical or major defects in the release scope	Fail	One open major defect on refund handling.
Critical-journey automated suite	Mandatory	Curated critical-journey suite green	Pass	All 40 checks green, 0% flaky this run.
Unit & API checks	Mandatory	CI unit and API checks green on the release build	Pass	Green.
Public API contract	Mandatory	Contract tests pass; no breaking change unversioned	Pass	No contract changes this release.
Risk-based exploratory testing	Mandatory	Charter-based exploratory testing of changed areas complete	Pass	Completed; findings triaged.
Regression of impacted areas	Advisory	Impacted-area regression complete	Pass	Cart and checkout covered.
Performance	Advisory	No known performance regression on key endpoints	N/A	No performance-sensitive change.
Rollback plan	Mandatory	Tested rollback / feature-flag kill switch available	Pass	Feature-flagged; kill switch verified.
Residual risk documented	Mandatory	Known risks recorded and accepted by the release owner	Pass	Documented.

Decision: NO-GO. Although eight of nine criteria pass, the open major defect on refund handling fails a mandatory criterion on a payments flow. The recommendation to the release owner is to fix or explicitly de-scope the refund change before releasing.

Blank reusable version

Criterion	Type	Pass condition	Status	Notes
Critical / major defects	Mandatory	No open critical or major defects in scope		
Automated checks (critical journeys)	Mandatory			
Unit & API checks	Mandatory			
Exploratory testing of changes	Mandatory			
Regression of impacted areas	Advisory			
Performance	Advisory			
Security / accessibility (if relevant)	Advisory			
Rollback / kill switch	Mandatory			
Residual risk documented & accepted	Mandatory			

Mark each Pass / Fail / N/A, then apply the decision rule. Add or remove criteria to fit your context and risk profile.

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Making every criterion mandatory, so the gate becomes a blunt "everything perfect or nothing ships" — which teams then quietly bypass under pressure. Defining pass conditions vaguely ("testing done") so the gate is argued about every time. Treating the gate as a QA veto rather than a recommendation to a business owner who owns the risk. Skipping the gate under deadline pressure — the one time it matters most. And failing to record accepted residual risk on a conditional-go, leaving no evidence of who decided what when the incident review arrives.

How to interpret the results

- Go — release with confidence, and keep the record.
- Conditional go — releasing is legitimate, but the residual risk and its owner must be written down. This is where mature teams operate most of the time; perfection is rarely available.
- No-go — a mandatory failure. Do not let seniority or deadline pressure override it silently; if the business chooses to release anyway, that becomes a documented business decision to accept the risk, made by the risk owner, not a QA decision.
- If the same criterion fails release after release, that is a signal about your process upstream, not just this release. Feed it back into your objectives.
- If the gate always says "go" with no debate, either you are genuinely in great shape or your pass conditions are too soft. Audit a recent release that had a production issue against the gate to calibrate.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Frame the gate's output as "here is the risk of releasing now, and here is who owns accepting it" rather than "QA says no". This turns you from the person who blocks releases into the person who gives the business a clear-eyed decision — which is exactly the reputation that gets QA invited earlier, where it can actually prevent the problems instead of catching them at the gate.